

A FRESH START

With the economy showing signs of revival, placements are no longer a nightmare for students across business schools

It is placement season and the Indian Institute of Management, Kozhikode, is buzzing with activity. Rohan Jaikishen, a second year student who has just landed his dream job in the human resources department of the Oil and Natural Gas Corporation, is celebrating with friends, who too have got jobs with the likes of Deutsche Bank, JP Morgan and Cognizant.

The recruiters are back on campus and with offers virtually pouring in, it is a far cry from last year when average salaries were down by 20-30 per cent and B-schools were struggling to place their entire batch. At the Institute of Rural Management, Anand (IRMA), which placed its 65 students the first day itself, 48 companies turned up, offering an average 2.5 jobs per student. The average salary was Rs 6 lakh per annum, an increase of 20 per cent over last year. At the Delhi-based Indian Institute of Foreign Trade (IIFT) the average domestic salary was Rs 11.6 lakh, even higher than Rs 10.1 lakh in the buoyant 2008, and the highest offer was at \$150,000 by Singapore-based trading company Olam International.

Companies which had frozen hiring or shied away last year, are coming back in strength. Mahindra & Mahindra, for instance, has hired 21 B-school graduates against nine last

year, while the Boston Consulting Group (BCG) plans to hire 30 students. At Indian Institute of Management-Ahmedabad (IIM-A), Deloitte made 10 offers (including lateral) for consulting roles while Tata Administrative Services and Feedback Ventures hired six students each. Overseas hiring is picking up too. While RBS offered roles across Hong Kong, Singapore and London to IIM-A students, Punj Lloyd and Sudima

which begins its final placements in March, saw 40 companies at the laterals process. Accenture, Mahindra & Mahindra, Star TV and Amazon.com were first time recruiters in this segment. In a batch size of 280, over 100 students had an offer in hand. Hariharan Sriram from the external relations team at the institute says they have seen an increase in compensation figures as compared to last year and packages of more than Rs 20 lakh per annum being offered to students. Adds Rajeev Dubey, president (HR, after-market and corporate services), Mahindra & Mahindra, "Our business plans are more bullish and so are our skill requirements. The war for talent is more intense this year."

Placement services officers, however, say they are "cautiously optimistic", unwilling to comment as recruitments are ongoing in many institutes. Recruiters say they are in the midst of finalising their employment or compensation projections for the year, but expect both to go up. "It is definitely an improvement over last year," says Abhishek Malhotra, partner, Booz & Company, India, while Ravi Srivastava, partner and director at BCG says, "Compensation packages will certainly not dip." For students, that may sound like music.

by Nandini Valish

COMPENSATION PACKAGES ARE NOT LIKELY TO DIP IN 2010



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International had openings in Malaysia and Singapore respectively for IIFT. But more importantly, it was the return of the coveted investment banks on campus that has got hopes up. "Last year students took up any job as they had EMIs to pay. But now, they are getting choosy again," says Munish Bhargava, placement coordinator, IIFT.

Lateral placements for students with prior work experience has seen a huge demand as well. IIM Calcutta,

age age of employees, PSU banks are running out of talent as many would retire in five years. Ergo, these banks are looking to hire over 40,000 people.

While most private banks are still cautious about adding manpower and giving salary increases, the more hungry players such as Axis Bank and Standard Chartered are expanding their footprint and, therefore, also looking at talent. Says Madhavi Lal, head of human resources, India and South

Asia, Standard Chartered: "Hiring has picked up in 2010. We want to expand our corporate and retail banking operations, so we are looking at hiring 2,500 people of which 100 will be from campuses." Axis Bank, for instance, is looking at opening 200 new branches in the next one year for which the bank will need 1,500 people. Says Snehomoy Bhattacharya, president, human resources, Axis Bank: "Corporate banking talent along with private

wealth management will be big and we will look for talent in these segments."

For those who are looking at a career in banking, it makes sense to enroll into a specialised banking course. In order to get talent that suits their needs, Standard Chartered has a tie-up with the S.P. Jain Institute of Management and Research, which has a specialised programme in banking and most of the batch has been placed.

with inputs from Nandini Valish